

A DATA STORY FROM TRUSTMRR

Inside the Indie Economy

What nearly 1,500 verified startup revenue streams reveal about who's building, who's winning, and who's quietly cashing out.

\$76.6M

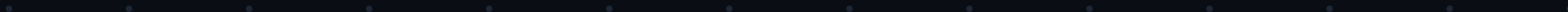
largest single startup, all-time revenue

\$0

the floor — hundreds start here

9

payment rails powering it all



THE DATASET

One database, one rule: show the real number

TrustMRR verifies startup revenue directly against the payment processor — no self-reported screenshots. The result is a rare, honest cross-section of the bootstrapped and venture-backed internet, side by side.

~1,500

startups tracked, from solo
founders to funded scale-ups

\$0 → \$76.6M

spread of lifetime revenue
across the dataset

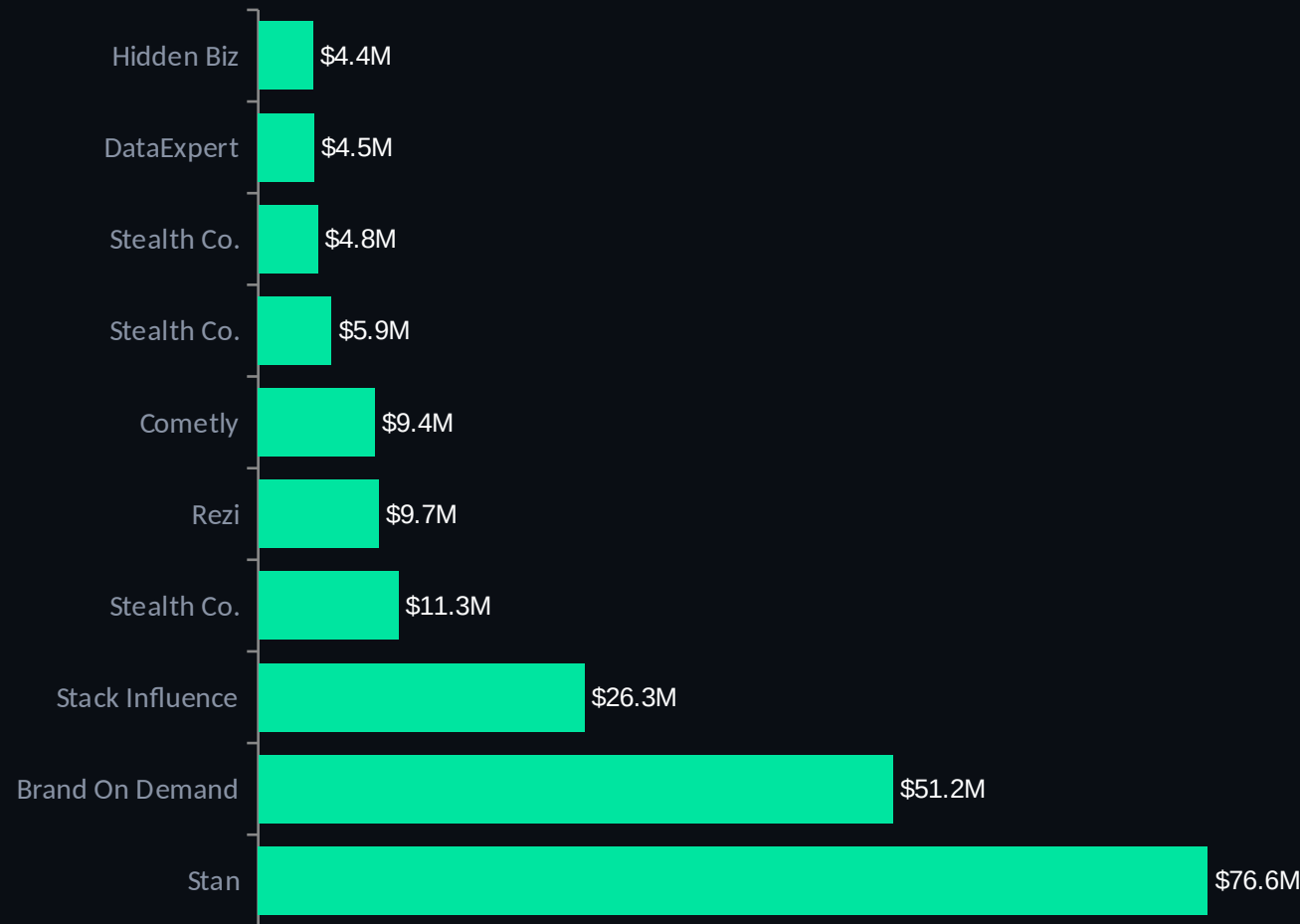
60+

countries represented, from
the US to Vietnam

9

payment providers, led by
Stripe, RevenueCat & Paddle

Ten companies out-earn nearly everyone else combined



\$204M+

combined lifetime revenue of just the top 10 startups in the dataset.

Meanwhile, the tail stretches for hundreds of entries — dozens of startups sit at exactly \$0 in trailing revenue, still building in public.

This is a classic power-law market: a handful of breakout platforms capture outsized revenue, while most founders are still fighting for their first dollar.

Stan: the biggest name in the dataset is losing steam

\$76.6M

all-time revenue

101,590

active subscriptions

\$3.57M

monthly recurring revenue

-7.6%

30-day revenue growth

Stan (stan.store) — a creator storefront platform — is the single largest verified startup in the dataset, more than 25× the size of the next-largest tracked competitor. But scale and momentum are not the same thing. Its monthly recurring revenue is still growing, barely — up just 0.4% in 30 days — while overall revenue in the same window actually contracted 7.6%. For a company this size, that's a meaningfully different story than the triple-digit growth rates found elsewhere in the same dataset.

THE LESSON

Being #1 in lifetime revenue doesn't guarantee #1 in momentum. Several startups a hundredth of Stan's size are compounding faster in the same 30-day window — proof that in this dataset, size and speed are two different games.

Somewhere, a tiny company just 100x'd overnight

Stealth Company (17)	+718.9%	30-day revenue growth	+12,983% MRR growth
1418 Technologies	+7,210%	30-day revenue growth	R&D / dev-tools startup
Hidden Digital Business	+220.2%	30-day revenue growth	+97.9% MRR growth
LLM Gateway	+49.7%	30-day revenue growth	+239.5% MRR growth

These aren't the biggest companies in the dataset — most sit under \$200K in lifetime revenue. But percentage growth doesn't care about size: a handful of new customers on a tiny base can register as a quadruple-digit spike.

“AI” isn't a category anymore — it's a default setting

Scan the category tags across the dataset and one label reappears more than any other: AI. It's not confined to one niche — it's stapled onto marketing tools, sales tools, content tools, dev tools, and education products alike.

AI content creation

AI SEO & GEO tools

AI sales & outreach agents

AI resume & career tools

AI video & image generation

AI customer support

AI text humanizers

AI coding copilots

AI compliance & audits

The pattern: founders aren't building “AI companies” so much as retrofitting every existing category of software with an AI layer — an SEO tool becomes an AI SEO agent, a support inbox becomes an AI support agent.

Stripe is the default. Everything else is a signal.

- **Stripe**

The overwhelming default across the dataset — the verification backbone for web SaaS, e-commerce, and agencies alike.

- **RevenueCat**

The clear #2, powering in-app subscriptions for the mobile-app long tail — fitness trackers, journaling apps, AI photo tools.

- **Whop / Lemon Squeezy / Polar / Creem / Dodo Payments**

The creator & indie-hacker stack — merchant-of-record tools built for solo founders who don't want to deal with tax and compliance.

- **Paddle / Superwall**

Read the payment-provider like a text: Stripe signals a conventional SaaS business; RevenueCat signals a mobile-first; Whop or Polar signals a solo builder optimizing for speed over flexibility.

Real revenue, no name attached

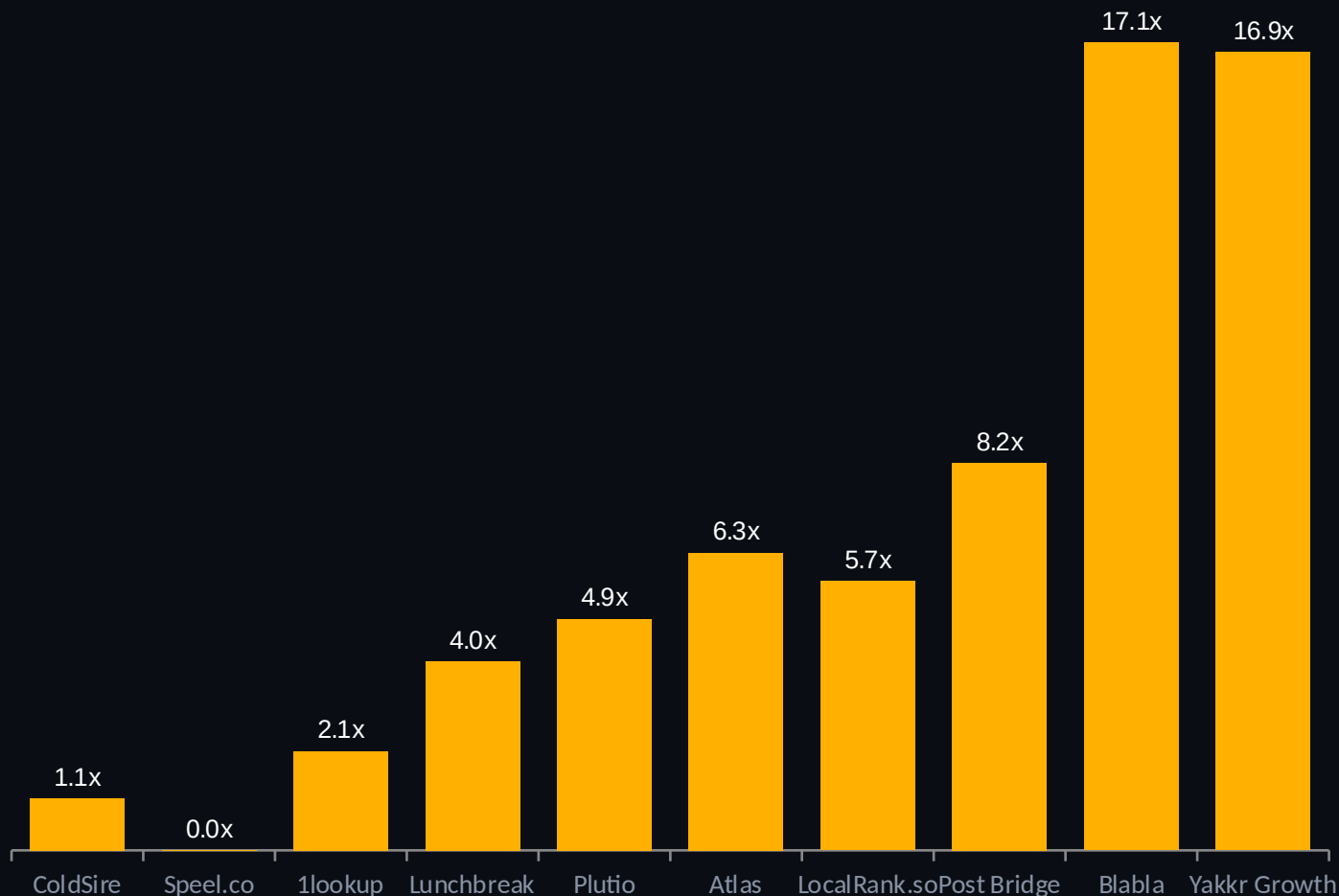
Scroll through the dataset and “Stealth Company” shows up again and again — founders willing to expose their exact Stripe numbers to the world, but not their brand. It's one of the stranger tensions built into a database whose entire premise is transparency.

Some of these anonymous entries aren't small, either — several stealth startups post six- and seven-figure lifetime revenue, and one is even listed for sale at a \$5,000,000 asking price without ever naming the product.

WHY GO STEALTH?

- Competitors can't reverse-engineer the strategy from the numbers.
- Founders can prove traction to buyers or investors without a public trail.
- A pending acquisition or fundraise is still confidential.
- The product itself is early, and the brand isn't ready for scrutiny.

The going rate for a bootstrapped startup



1x – 8x

is where most listed startups in the dataset trade, priced against trailing revenue.

But outliers exist on both ends: a handful of businesses list at 15x–20x+ when growth is white-hot, while a few sell below 1x when revenue is stalling or near zero.

Takeaway: growth rate — not size — is what buyers pay a premium for.

Five takeaways

01

A power law, not a bell curve.

A handful of platforms earn more than hundreds of others combined — and the gap keeps widening.

02

Size $\neq$ speed.

The biggest name in the dataset is contracting; some of the smallest are up 1,000%+ in a month.

03

AI is the default coat of paint.

It's less a category now than a feature every product claims to have.

04

Infrastructure reveals strategy.

The payment provider a founder picks quietly signals who they're building for.

05

Anonymity has a price — literally.

Stealth founders will show you the revenue before they'll show you the brand.